

Bridewell Palace

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THE HERITAGE of FLEET STREET

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Bridewell Palace has had many uses over the last 500 years. It was once a royal palace, a prison, a school, and a hospital. Today, only a copy of its old gatehouse still stands on New Bridge Street.

The palace was built in 1510 and given to King Henry VIII by Cardinal Wolsey in 1515. It was named after St Bride's Church and a holy spring nearby. The palace had large courtyards, gardens, and a grand staircase that later inspired designs in other palaces, including Hampton Court.

Bridewell Palace was also important in English history. It was where Henry VIII tried to end his marriage to Catherine of Aragon. Later, French ambassadors stayed there, inspiring Holbein's famous painting, *The Ambassadors*.

In 1553, King Edward VI changed the palace into a prison and later added a hospital. By 1921, the remaining land was turned into offices for Lever Bros, which later became Unilever.



*Hans Holbein the Younger's painting
'the Ambassadors'*



*1553 Bridewell Palace and
the Fleet River*



*A replica of Bridewell Palace's
Gatehouse on 14 New Bridge Street*